UNESCO World Heritage Sites from Major Cities

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Introduction

UNESCO World Heritage Sites (WHC) represent places of outstanding cultural and natural significance across the globe. While these sites are globally distributed, their accessibility to nearby cities varies widely depending on site type and geographic context. Cultural heritage sites are often located in or near urban centers, while natural heritage sites are more frequently situated in remote or protected areas. This project examines how accessible UNESCO World Heritage Sites are from major global cities, with a specific focus on comparing cultural versus natural site.

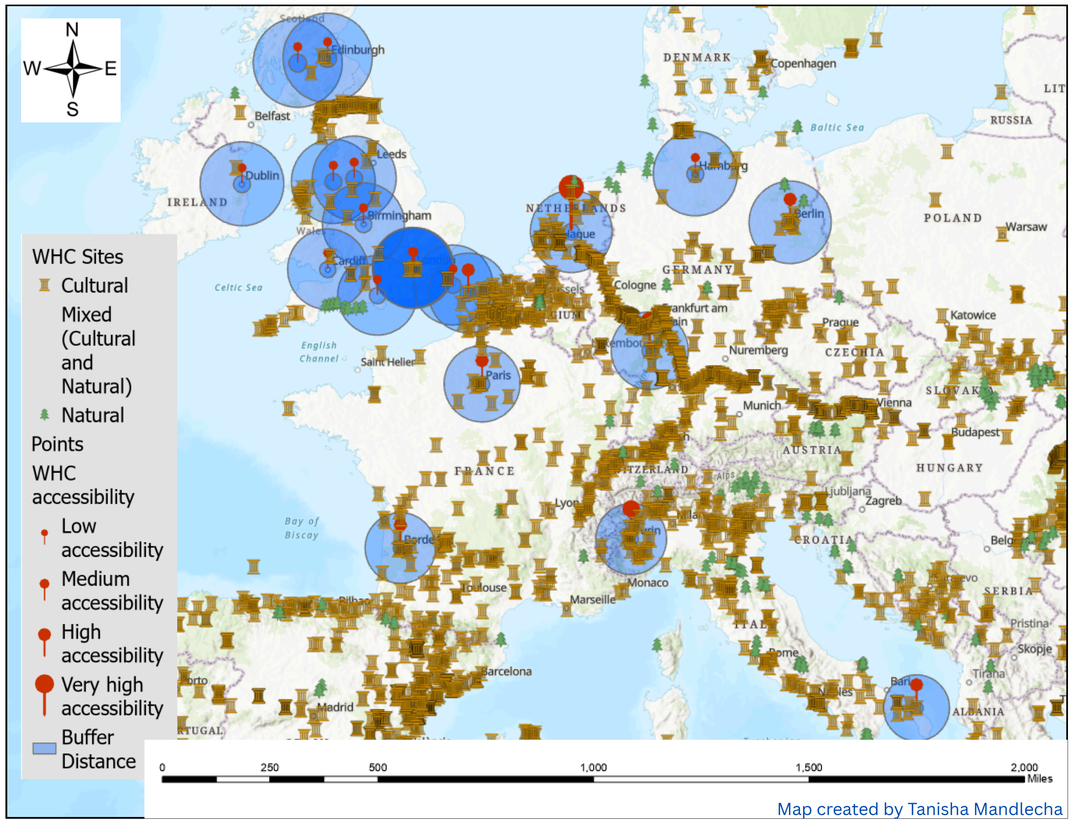
Methods

Spatial data for UNESCO World Heritage Sites were obtained from the UNESCO World Heritage Centre, including site locations and classification as Cultural, Natural, or Mixed. The analysis was conducted in ArcGIS Pro and involved the following steps:

- UNESCO World Heritage Site layers were merged into a single point dataset with a categorical attribute (property_category).
- A Buffer and Near analysis was performed to calculate the distance from each World Heritage Site to the nearest city within a 100 km search radius.
- Distance values were classified into accessibility bands:
  - 0–20 km (walking or immediate access)
  - 20–100 km (day-trip access)
  - No City within 100 km
- Summary statistics were generated to compare accessibility across sites.
- Cities were ranked by the number of nearby World Heritage Sites, allowing identification of global hubs with high cultural accessibility (Table 1).

Place	No. of Sites
Netherlands	48
Worms, Germany	30
Turin	25
Nagasaki	21
Jordan River	20
Yokohama	19
Mexico	19
Peru	13
Calais	12
Dead Sea	12

Table 1 shows the top 10 locations with the highest number of heritage sites.



Map created by Tanisha Mandlecha

Results

Heritage sites are highly concentrated in Europe, with dense clusters in Western and Central Europe. Cultural sites dominate the dataset, while natural and mixed sites are fewer and more spatially dispersed.

Proximity to Urban Centers:

Buffer analysis shows that most cultural heritage sites are located outside major urban areas, with 5,095 sites classified as “No City.” Smaller shares fall within 20–100 km (264 sites) and 0–20 km (74 sites) of cities. Natural sites are even more likely to be located beyond urban buffers.

Top 10 Locations by Site Count:

The top-ranking locations by number of heritage sites include the Netherlands (48), Worms, Germany (30), and Turin, Italy (25). Other high-density locations such as Nagasaki, the Jordan River, Yokohama, and Mexico highlight globally significant historical and cultural centers.

Analysis / Discussion

The analysis reveals strong geographic clustering of global heritage sites, with cultural sites concentrated in historically dense regions, especially Europe. This pattern reflects long histories of urban development, political significance, and sustained preservation efforts.

Buffer analysis shows that while heritage sites are linked to urban centers, many are located outside immediate city boundaries, likely due to conservation priorities, historical land use, and spatial constraints within modern cities.

Top-ranking locations such as Turin and Worms highlight the connection between historical importance and site density, while sites like the Jordan River and Nagasaki demonstrate that heritage recognition extends beyond Europe to globally significant cultural landscapes.

References

UNESCO World Heritage Centre. World Heritage Sites. Data accessed via ArcGIS Online

Esri. World Cities Dataset. ArcGIS Online